

about its end-to-end encryption and whether the chats of the people were safe and weren't being read by third parties.

With so much going on, people and the governments become more alarmed not only about the fake profiles but also the apps which they use. This has led to the development of certain software which protects the users from possible attacks, online.

Recently, the UK government launched an app, to help prevent users from falling prey to foreign spies through social media platforms. The Center for Protection of National Infrastructure (CPNI), UK's national security, launched the app, "Think before you Link" allowing users of social media platforms such as LinkedIn and Facebook to identify fake profiles used by foreign spies and other malicious actors. This app will help people spot suspicious profiles.



According to MI5, around 10,000 UK nationals were targeted by fake profiles on LinkedIn and Facebook. Spies from other nationalities tend to make fake profiles and lure people into passing on sensitive information. Spies in the past have approached people who have access to sensitive information and due to the online world this problem has escalated. The online world has given them an easy path with much easier access to people.

The app is mainly aimed at aiding government officials, as current and former employees are more at risk of passing on sensitive information.

But common people in the UK can still download it and use it for free, from the day it launched.

FEATURES OF THINK BEFORE YOU LINK:

- The app is designed with the help of behavioural scientists. It prompts the user with a series of questions in order to assess if the person who approached them might be fake.
 - The special assessing feature will look out for offers which seem flattering and warn the user about the same.
 - In order to make the app more interesting, the users will be able to earn trophies and will be able to share it with the security team, according to the app's website.
 - To identify fake pictures, the app also includes an in-built reverse image search which will spot pictures if they were re-used from a site, as this is one of the most prominent features of creating a fake profile.
 - Based on the user's remarks, the app will categorise a certain profile as low, medium or high risk. If the profile is medium or high then it recommends the user to report it.
- However, the app doesn't have a specific database of spies, and it can't provide a definitive answer. But it is created in to highlight potential risks.

This was one of the moves done by the UK government to combat threats online. In India, however, there haven't been any such app which could help us in detecting fake profiles, yet. But there surely are certain methods with which one can determine fake profiles on their own.

METHODS TO CHECK FAKE PROFILES:

1. If the person is famous and is in the public eye, such personalities have a blue tick on their profiles. This tick determines the authenticity of the said profile. The blue tick means that the account is verified, meaning that the account is identified by that particular platform. Almost all the public figures have a blue tick on their profiles and on all the social media platforms.

2. If the person is not a public figure, one way to check the authenticity is by checking the interactions of that profile. The number of followers, the number of following and especially paying attention to the number of posts, is one of the easiest ways of determining if the account is fake. Someone with 1 thousand followers and 0 following with no posts, is almost definitely a fake account.
3. Another way of checking interactions is through checking the type of posts which are present on the account. If the posts are all promotional and if you get direct messages from that account which also suggest promotional messages and even messages such as asking for help or provide offers promoting their product or even working for them, beware of such accounts, these are created to lure people and get money in some cases.
4. If you are suspicious about certain pictures, then there are tools through which you can see if the image is authentic or reused. The reverse image search feature is available on Google, Yandex and Bing. Through these tools you can easily find out if the image was taken from the web or surfaced anywhere else online.
5. Another way to check the authenticity of a profile is by checking the account name on other platforms. If a profile has a certain name on Instagram, then the best way to check if it's real or not is by checking the profile on LinkedIn and Twitter and vice versa.
6. Check for their online behaviour. The kind of stuff they post and the people they interact with through comments etc.

Through the advent of social media, the use of deep fakes and fake news, fake profiles have been on the rise. As the users of social media, it becomes tough for us to trust technology with our privacy. The key here to stay safe from such things, is being cautious. Our safety relies in our very hands. So be wary of people who slide into your DMs unannounced. 